

86 Naaman

A proud Syrian general who was healed when he humbled himself and washed in the Jordan.

Naaman commanded the army of Syria, Israel's enemy to the north. He was powerful, honoured and brave, but he had leprosy. A young Israelite girl, taken captive in a raid and now serving his wife, told her mistress about a prophet in Samaria who could heal him. Naaman arrived at Elisha's door with horses, chariots and a fortune in gifts. The prophet did not even come out. He sent a message: go and wash in the Jordan seven times. Naaman stormed off in a rage. It took his own servants to talk him round. When he obeyed, his skin became like a child's, and he confessed that there was no God in all the earth but in Israel. Jesus later used his healing to show that God's grace reaches outsiders.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Naaman</i> , "pleasant"
Position	Captain of the host of the king of Syria (2 Kings 5:1)
Condition	"A mighty man in valour, but he was a leper" (2 Kings 5:1)
When	Elisha's ministry, probably in the reign of Joram of Israel, c. 852–841 BC
Key places	Damascus, Samaria, the Jordan River
Key people	The captive Israelite girl, the king of Syria, the king of Israel, Elisha, Gehazi
New Testament	Named by Jesus in Nazareth (Luke 4:27)

"Then went he down, and dipped himself seven times in Jordan, according to the saying of the man of God: and his flesh came again like unto the flesh of a little child, and he was clean."

2 Kings 5:14, KJV

The life of Naaman

Scripture gives no date. The kings of Syria and Israel are not named in 2 Kings 5. They were probably Ben-hadad and Joram, c. 852–841 BC.

Before the story	● A great commander Naaman is highly honoured by his king, because through him the LORD has given victory to Syria. He is a mighty man of valour, but he has leprosy. <i>2 Kings 5:1</i>
In his household	● A servant girl speaks Syrian raiders have taken a young girl from Israel, and she now serves Naaman's wife. She says she wishes her master could meet the prophet in Samaria, who would heal him. <i>2 Kings 5:2–4</i>
A royal letter	● Sent to Israel The king of Syria sends Naaman with a letter and rich gifts to the king of Israel. The king tears his clothes, fearing a trap, but Elisha asks for Naaman to be sent to him. <i>2 Kings 5:5–8</i>
At Elisha's door	● Angry at the cure Elisha sends a messenger: wash in the Jordan seven times. Naaman is furious. He expected a ceremony, and he thinks Damascus has better rivers. His servants gently persuade him. <i>2 Kings 5:9–13</i>
At the Jordan	● Healed He dips himself seven times, and his flesh becomes like a little child's. He returns to Elisha, confesses Israel's God, and asks for earth to take home for worship. <i>2 Kings 5:14–19</i>
On the road	● Gehazi's lie Elisha's servant runs after him and invents a need for silver and clothing. Naaman gladly gives double. Gehazi is struck with Naaman's leprosy. <i>2 Kings 5:20–27</i>

Key activities

Naaman's story turns on unnamed, lowly people. A captive girl, a messenger and his own servants point him to healing, while two kings can do nothing.

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- 1 Listened to a servant girl.** He took the word of a young captive seriously enough to tell his king. *2 Kings 5:2-4*
 - 2 Went in style.** He brought ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold and ten changes of clothing. *2 Kings 5:5, 9*
 - 3 Took offence.** He expected Elisha to come out, call on his God, and strike his hand over the place. He said, "Are not Abana and Pharpar, rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel?" *2 Kings 5:11-12*
 - 4 Heeded his servants.** They asked, "if the prophet had bid thee do some great thing, wouldest thou not have done it?" *2 Kings 5:13*
 - 5 Obeyed and was healed.** He dipped seven times in the Jordan, just as the man of God had said. *2 Kings 5:14*
 - 6 Confessed the true God.** "Behold, now I know that there is no God in all the earth, but in Israel." *2 Kings 5:15*
 - 7 Asked for earth and pardon.** He took two mules' load of earth and asked pardon for bowing beside his master in the house of Rimmon. Elisha said, "Go in peace." *2 Kings 5:17-19*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Naaman.

Old Testament

2 Kings 5:1-27	This is the only account of his life.
Leviticus 13-14	The law for leprosy and for cleansing a healed leper.
Echo: Isaiah 45:22	Salvation for "all the ends of the earth"

New Testament

Luke 4:27	None cleansed "saving Naaman the Syrian"; Nazareth is enraged
Echo: Luke 17:11-19	Of ten lepers healed, only a Samaritan gives thanks
Echo: John 9:7	A blind man washes in Siloam and comes back seeing

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Naaman expect Elisha to do, and why was he so angry (2 Kings 5:11-12)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Elisha refused Naaman's gifts, and why was Gehazi's lie so serious?
3. *Apply:* Naaman almost missed healing because the cure was too simple and too humbling. Where does pride keep you from doing something simple that God asks?
4. *Apply:* A servant girl and a few servants changed Naaman's life. Who might God use you to point toward him this week?